In most cases, ACME responded by improving the system in targeted ways. Policies were clarified, enforcement logic was consolidated, and new governance checkpoints were added. These changes provided real benefits. Teams learned from each experience, strengthening both their technical approach and their understanding of how access decisions shaped user outcomes. Individually, none of these events seemed existential. But when viewed together, they began to reveal a pattern.

As Customer Collaboration expanded, ACME's *decision surface*, the total set of situations in which access must be evaluated, grew faster than its decision infrastructure. More employees were interacting with more customers across more systems. Automation reduced the need for human intervention but increased the number of actions performed. Contextual signals such as device posture, location, and workload status started influencing outcomes in ways that were hard to test thoroughly. Decisions were no longer evaluated only at the boundaries of applications, but increasingly as part of how systems operated in real time. The organization's ability to explain how access decisions were made lagged behind its capacity to implement new features.

The company continued to invest in targeted improvements. Shared policy services were introduced to reduce duplication. Relationship-based models replaced rigid role hierarchies in key workflows. Attribute-driven controls improved assurance in high-risk scenarios. Each step made the platform more coherent and more adaptable. Yet each step also expanded expectations about what the system could support.

As shown in Figure 19.1, the gap between the decision surface and decision infrastructure created *authorization pressure*—the increasing difficulty of making decisions consistently, explaining outcomes, and maintaining control as systems scale—resulting in both operational friction and strategic uncertainty. Product leaders had to balance trade-offs between feature speed and consistent performance. Sales teams found it difficult to reassure potential partners that complex collaboration scenarios could be managed without custom engineering. Security teams identified risks resulting from the accumulation of implicit trust relationships embedded in code and configuration.